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Book review

Systemic Functional Linguistics and Translation Studies, Mira Kim, Jeremy Munday, Zhenhua Wang, Pin Wang (Eds.). Bloomsbury Academic, London/New York (2021). xvi + 242 pp. ISBN 978-1-3500-9186-3, GBP 130 (hardback).

Systemic functional linguistics (SFL) represents a prominent and relatively comprehensive functional approach to language as communication. As a well-established area in linguistics, SFL aims to provide in-depth and elaborate discussions on different grammatical categories and their corresponding functions in language. So far, it has focused on detailed descriptions of such (major) languages as English, Chinese, Korean, Japanese, Spanish and French. The idea of 'meaning potential' is at the core of SFL, which refers to the range of semiotic resources that are available to each language. One of the advantages of SFL is that there is often 'a clearly defined link' (p. 87) between certain lexicogrammatical realisations and their respective communicative effects. Translation studies (TS) in comparison is the systematic study of the different aspects of translation (e.g. the process, product, practice, and the translator) in various contexts and from different perspectives, which has been a rapidly growing area over the past few decades since the publication of the foundational paper by James S. Holmes in 1972 entitled 'The Name and Nature of Translation Studies'.

Despite being two seemingly disparate areas on the surface, SFL, as a matter of fact, overlaps with TS in interesting ways (particularly with sections of TS that focus on exploring the functional and communicative aspects of the source text and target text from a textual or discourse analytic perspective). While the application of SFL to translation studies is not entirely new (Kim and Matthiessen, 2015; Munday, 2012), it certainly represents a rapidly developing area. This new Bloomsbury book edited by Mira Kim, Jeremy Munday, Zhenhua Wang and Pin Wang takes stock of the latest developments in the area from a range of theoretical, methodological and practical perspectives, providing us with renewed understandings of to how SFL might be better applied to translation studies in various settings and contexts. The book did not come out of nowhere. As alluded to in the book, this edited volume came into being after two successful international conferences held at the University of New South Wales and the Martin Centre for Appliable Linguistics of Shanghai Jiao Tong University respectively around this theme.

Consisting of 10 chapters in total, this exciting book brings together world-leading experts and scholars from such locales as Germany, UK, Australia, China, Saudi Arabia and Brazil, whose research interests straddle both areas. In terms of the overall structure and orientation, Chapters 1–5 are more theoretically and methodologically oriented, whereas Chapters 6–9 are practical and empirical studies. The last chapter (Chapter 10) seemingly combines both the theoretical and practical dimensions through introducing an interesting quantitative mathematical approach. These chapters emphasise the great strides made and also the future research potentials, harnessing the two areas in linguistic research.

Focusing on functional language typology, in Chapter 1, the authors J. R. Martin and Beatriz Quiroz have compared and contrasted the TENSE systems between English and Spanish. For illustrative purposes, four short texts (2 English STs and 2 Spanish STs) and their corresponding translated versions were analysed. For the authors, axis, delicacy, rank, and stratification within an SFL paradigm may help explain the similarities and differences between various languages. Erich Steiner in Chapter 2 has explored the idea of 'textual instantiation'. Specifically, he examined how the concept 'readings of texts' can help shed light on the area of translation studies. In different types of readings, translators arguably act as translational agents and need to make choices and decisions constantly in the translation process. Such decision-making is inevitably contextualised in nature and influenced by both the source texts and the target texts. In Chapter 3, Stella Neumann zoomed in on the nexus between register and translation, focusing in particular on the relevance of register to translation. As opposed to previous functional theories of text type, the SFL-informed register architecture featuring field, tenor, and mode seemingly offers a more robust framework, thus making it possible to better account for the essentially dynamic, complex, multidimensional and multifunctional nature of situation contexts and to deliver more in-depth and systematic analysis of contextual features evidenced in source and target texts.

In Chapter 4, Jeremy Munday, a prominent figure in applying SFL-inspired perspectives to translation studies, has reflected upon the use of systemic functional linguistics as a framework for analysing translators and interpreters' stance-taking, positioning and intervention. In the chapter, the author emphasised the common ground between TS and SFL because both 'SFL and TS place a premium on language as functional communication" (p. 84). This serves as a fundamental reason why

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the two areas are compatible. Specifically, his chapter aimed to address three relevant questions: What are the reasons for using an SFL-based model to analyse the translator's choices? How successful is it? and How might the model be best applied? Jeremy Munday's chapter is highly relevant, promising to shape our understandings and provide an enhanced conceptual framework for research relating to SFL and TS. The reflections around the practical issues when applying SFL to comparative studies between the source and target texts in translation are particularly inspiring.

Chapter 5, by Ekaterina Lapshinova-Koltunski, details in-depth how corpus linguistics approaches can be meaningfully incorporated to studies involving both SFL and translation studies for more systematic findings. In particular, for the author, SFL theory can interact with corpus-based translation studies in two major ways, that is, a theory-driven approach and a data-driven approach. For the former, potentially salient features discussed in SFL theories can serve as a useful point of departure for analysing the translated texts. In addition, a more data-driven approach can also be adopted, inter alia, to find out interesting (universalist) features of translations (e.g. normalisation, shining through, explicitation, and simplification) as compared with non-translated ones. The discussions and reflections in this chapter are highly relevant given the fact that corpus linguistics approaches are increasingly used in translation studies and language studies in general for more systematic, objective and convincing findings as part of the broader trends of digital humanities.

Moving beyond the theoretical and methodological reflections, the following few chapters deal with practical and empirical studies of translation from different perspectives. In Chapter 6, Xueying Li and Mira Kim carried out a descriptive study on translation choices for logical meanings between Chinese and English, drawing on data from the classical Chinese novel *Hong Lou Meng*. In Chapter 7, Komail Al Herz explored modality and carried out a systemic functional analysis of two Arabic translations of J.M. Coetzee's *Waiting for the Barbarians*. In the analysis, different forms of optional modality shifts were categorised into four types and discussions were provided in detail. This chapter contributes to our understanding of the use of SFL in the Arabic context. In the empirical study carried out by Sami J. Althumali in Chapter 8, the author carried out an experiment amongst Arab students at a university level to test how the SFL model can be effectively applied to translator training and translation assessment in English-Arabic translation. The experiment illustrated that the students with some knowledge of SFL tended to show significant signs of improvement in their translation performance in different ways. This therefore adds an interesting pedagogical and training perspective to the area of applied translation studies. In Chapter 9, Long Li explored translated book covers from an interesting social-semiotic and diachronic perspective. To do so, the author examined verbal as well as visual elements in a descriptive study of 6 book covers of *Wild Swans* by Jung Chang, drawing on SFL-inspired frameworks. This study contributes to scholarship in translation studies from a multimodal point of view. Last but not least, in Chapter 10 entitled 'Shifting the gaze to the paradigm: Translation as tool for multilingual studies', Giacomo Figueredo's contribution is thought-provoking, adding to the discussions from an interesting multilingual dimension.

To sum up, this edited volume has taken stock of the latest developments in the application of SFL to translation studies, covering such languages as English, Arabic, German, Spanish, Portuguese, and Chinese. Also, this book constitutes a welcome addition to relevant areas by exploring various topics and issues (e.g. literary translation, translator's intervention, translator training and assessment) from different perspectives (e.g. multimodal, multilingual, corpus linguistics, and discourse analysis perspectives). In addition, we find the reflective discussions on the practical issues and challenges of applying SFL most revealing. For example, as researchers working in the related field of (critical) discourse analysis, we particularly echo the most insightful observations made in Jeremy Munday's chapter. As he eloquently discussed, in the actual application of SFL in translation studies some aspects of the theory might be dauntingly complicated and elaborate and some linguistic and grammatical categories/dimensions in the framework might be slightly problematic for systematic and objective operationalisation (e.g. certain words can be subsumed under different categories). As such, for him, some categories/dimensions might be more relevant and straightforward than others. In addition, we also strongly agree with his observations some of the (elaborate and detailed) discussions in the SFL framework might not be immediately relevant in practice for translation researchers if there are no salient translation shifts in the process, given the essentially comparative nature of translation between two languages.

As some small and minor limitations, most of the focus has been placed on written translation. Translation in other modes (e.g. interpreting) has received relatively scant attention in the volume. Also, despite the fact that a range of languages are covered, most of these are still relatively well-researched major, dominant or Western languages. It would be interesting to see how relevant theories and approaches can be used in smaller, less dominant or even marginalised languages (e.g. Swahili, Polish, Ukrainian, Nepali, Punjabi, Welsh, Tagalog, and Bahasa Indonesia). In addition, the bulk of the book is concerned with the (one-way) application of SFL to translation studies. The fact that translation studies is often on the receiving end is understandable as SFL is a theory and framework and it is applied to help better understand translation. However, going forward, perhaps more attention might be focused on how translation (essentially a kind of bilingual communication between two languages) can in turn contribute to SFL. Given the bilingual and contrastive nature of translation, it may well add interesting comparative perspectives to the theorisation of SFL and language in general.

All in all, bringing together world-leading experts, this exciting new book provides us with a renewed understanding of the dynamic interaction between translation studies and SFL, introducing the most up-to-date developments in the area with both theoretical and practical implications. This book should be of interest to researchers, scholars and advanced students alike who are keen on the social and functional aspects of language use in our societies.

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